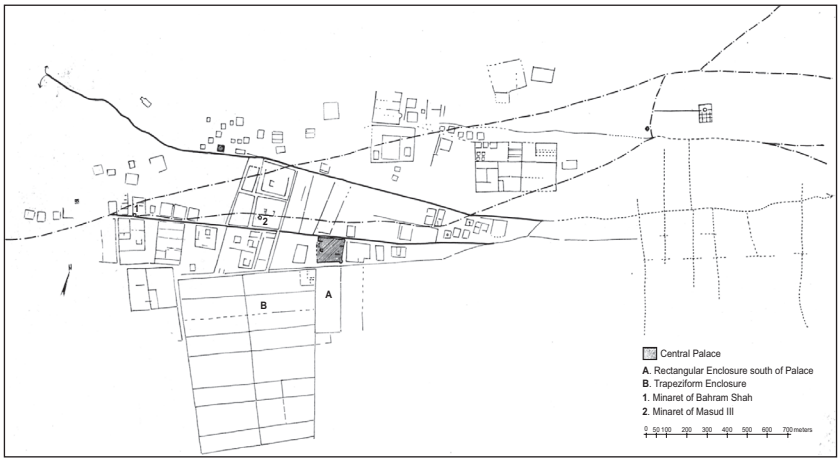


Figure 5.1 *Ghazna, plan from aerial photograph of western part of city. From Scerrato 1959: fig. 17.*

Zabulistan and Zamindawar, through the easternmost borders of Sistan (maps, pp. xv and xvi).

The central palace of Ghazna (Figures 5.1 and 5.2), to the east of the *minar* of Mas'ud III – and surely falling in the shadow of the originally much taller tower (Figure I.20) – was previously attributed to this sultan through a web of tangential associations. But recent re-examination of the archaeological data from this vast complex has led to a new understanding of the palace, encompassing a considerably more complicated architectural development likely beginning at least a half-century before the reign of Mas'ud III (r. AH 492–509/1099–1115 CE), and unfolding *via* several identifiable phases.[21] Ongoing studies of the palace's terracotta and stucco architectural decoration strongly suggest that a visible and perhaps substantial mark was left there in the wake of the Shansabani victory of AH 569/1173 CE as well.

More than three thousand terracotta and nearly seven hundred stucco elements from the palace's decoration – many with epigraphy – are undergoing detailed study and recontextualization within the palace's various building phases (Figures 5.3–5.5). These decorative components still carry traces of paint, indicating their original polychromy.[22] Among the terracotta remains, several broken pieces retrieved from the northeastern and southern zones of the palace's large central courtyard carried decipherable epigraphic fragments. Some inscriptions were simple doxologies (e.g., *al-mulk li-llah*), echoing the simplicity of the inscriptional frieze likely running along the walls of the palace's principal northern entrance.[23] However, other fragments have been read as being part of a longer frieze containing the *kunya* and *laqab*s of Sultan Mu'izz al-Din.[24]

These fragments bear an undeniable resemblance to the partial epigraphic